NORTHSTAR
DIGITAL SERVICES

HR Policy Exception Register

HR ONLY

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Prepared as synthetic content for a role-based retrieval-augmented generation (RAG) demonstration. This document is not an actual company policy.

Access classification: HR ONLY

1. Purpose, access and exception principles

Policy owner: HR Operations

Confidentiality classification

HR CONFIDENTIAL — synthetic register and workflow for demonstration. Only authorized HR personnel may access individual entries.

Purpose

The register tracks requests to depart from standard HR policies, the rationale, risk review, approval, expiry and follow-up. It creates an auditable record and helps identify repeated exceptions that may indicate a policy problem.

What qualifies

Examples include a proposed exception to an internal notice guideline, a non-standard benefit arrangement, a policy deadline extension or an approved process deviation. A register entry cannot waive statutory rights or override a contract or law.

Principles

Exceptions should be rare, justified, time-bound, consistent with law and approved by the proper authority. Similar cases should be considered consistently, while material differences should be documented.

Required fields

Each entry should include a unique case ID, policy name and version, requesting business unit, request date, business rationale, employee impact, risk assessment, decision, approver, effective date, expiry date and review owner.

No informal commitments

HR or managers must not promise an exception before required review. Verbal discussions should be recorded and are not approval unless the formal process explicitly permits them.

2. Review workflow and sample synthetic entries

Policy owner: HR Operations

Step 1 — completeness

Confirm the request describes the normal rule, requested deviation, reason, duration and impacted parties. Return incomplete requests for clarification.

Step 2 — eligibility and legality

Check whether the policy allows discretion and whether employment law, contract terms, collective arrangements or protected rights constrain the decision. Consult Legal when needed.

Step 3 — impact and precedent

Assess fairness, operational impact, privacy, cost, security and whether approving the request would create an unintended precedent. Compare relevant prior cases without exposing unrelated personal details.

Step 4 — approval

Route to the authority named in the delegation matrix. The requester should not approve their own request. Record approval or rejection with date and rationale.

Step 5 — communicate and monitor

Notify only the people who need to implement the decision. Record conditions, expiry and review reminders; confirm that the exception ends or is renewed through a fresh approval.

Synthetic entry EX-001

Policy: internal training completion deadline. Request: seven-day extension due to a documented system outage. Illustrative decision: approved by HR Operations for one cycle; owner to verify completion. This is fictional.

Synthetic entry EX-002

Policy: standard onboarding sequence. Request: alternate order for a remote hire because equipment delivery is delayed. Illustrative decision: approved with security prerequisites unchanged and a named follow-up owner. This is fictional.

3. Audit, renewal and governance

Policy owner: HR Operations

Expiry control

Run a periodic report of exceptions due to expire, already expired or missing a review owner. Expired exceptions should not continue by habit; obtain a new approval if the underlying need remains.

Trend analysis

Review exception volumes by policy, business unit, reason and outcome. Repeated requests may indicate unclear wording, impractical controls or inequitable implementation. Use aggregated reporting where possible.

Access and privacy

Restrict individual entries to HR staff with a legitimate need. Managers may receive only the decision and implementation details required for their work, not the entire register or unrelated case history.

Audit trail

Retain the original request, risk assessment, approvals, communications and closure evidence. Corrections should preserve history and identify who changed the record and why.

Red flags

Escalate requests involving possible discrimination, retaliation, conflicts of interest, sensitive personal data, statutory entitlements, unusually large financial impact or attempts to bypass approval controls.

Sample entry EX-003

Policy: expense-document submission deadline. Request: brief extension due to a travel disruption. Illustrative decision: conditional approval subject to Finance confirming acceptable evidence. This synthetic entry is not a real employee case.

Ownership and review

HR Operations owns the register process; Legal, Compliance, Finance or Security are consulted based on risk. Review the process annually and ensure access permissions match the HR-only classification.